

APPROACHES, BEHAVIOURALISM AND POST-BEHAVIOURALISM

UPSC PRELIMS + GS MAINS | PRIMARY HOME: GS-II CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS

Continuous core-first rail | Advanced enrichment stays subordinate to the GS core

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ORIGIN AND DATED RAIL

1859	Preface to A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy
1921	Study of Politics' published in American Political Science Review
1925	New Aspects of Politics
1925	American Political Science Association
1927	Catlin, in his Science and Method of Politics
1936	Who Gets What, When, How
1953	Weldon, in his Vocabulary of Politics
1962	Thomas Kuhn's The Structure of Scientific Revolutions
1966	A Developmental Approach
MECHANISM	Chronology fixes what each named work actually changed, so the argument cannot slide into a vague rise-and-fall story.
TRAP / LIMIT	Method and approach are synonyms -> Approach is wider because it includes selection-criteria for problems and data. (PDF pp.108-109)
ANSWER LINE	Method means procedure of inquiry; approach means procedure plus criteria for selecting problems and data. (PDF pp.108-109)

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CORE DEFINITIONS THE EXAMINER EXPECTS VERBATIM

Term	Exam-ready meaning
Method	The procedure of inquiry by which reliable knowledge and conclusions are obtained. (PDF p.108)
Approach	A wider frame that includes method plus criteria for selecting problems, questions and relevant data. (PDF pp.108-109)
Empirical statement	A claim about an observable situation that can be tested or verified by repeated observation. (PDF pp.110-111)
Normative statement	A claim expressing a preference, duty or moral principle about what ought to be valued or prescribed. (PDF pp.110-112)
Behaviouralism	A scientific orientation focusing on actual political behaviour, especially of actors such as voters, leaders and groups. (PDF pp.118-121)
Post-behaviouralism	A corrective within behavioural political science stressing relevance, action and concern for values. (PDF pp.121-122)
MECHANISM	Definition control is the cheapest mark in this topic: the stem is usually built from one of these exact terms.
TRAP / LIMIT	Traditional always means normative, and contemporary always means empirical -> Gauba explicitly rejects that mechanical equation. (PDF pp.109-110)
ANSWER LINE	Term - Exam-ready meaning

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CHAPTER SPINE, STEP BY STEP

- Gauba begins by separating method from approach so that students do not confuse tools of inquiry with frames of inquiry. (PDF pp.108-109)
- He then warns that traditional/contemporary and normative/empirical are not identical pairs. (PDF pp.109-110)
- He clarifies that empirical vs normative turns on the content of the claim, not just the grammatical presence of "is" or "ought". (PDF pp.110-112)
- The traditional approaches are then outlined: philosophical, historical, legal and institutional. (PDF pp.112-117)
- The contemporary shift is marked by behaviouralism, post-behaviouralism and several models of political analysis. (PDF pp.117-134)
- The chapter's deeper message is integrative: political science is weakened both by value-blind technique and by unsupported moral assertion

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- MECHANISM

The spine is the order in which the source itself develops the argument; reproducing it keeps the answer sequenced rather than listed.
- TRAP / LIMIT

Any sentence with "ought" is normative -> Its content may still be empirical if it states an instrumentally testable condition. (PDF pp.110-111)
- ANSWER LINE

Method vs approach: methods obtain and use data; approaches decide which questions and data count as relevant. (PDF pp.108-109)

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THINKERS, NAMED WORKS AND THE PROPOSITIONS THEY FIX

Vernon Van Dyke
Clarifies the distinction between approach and method and explains philosophical analysis as conceptual clarification plus evaluation. (PDF pp.108-109, 113)

Leo Strauss
Defends political philosophy as inseparable from facts and values and criticizes behavioural value-neutrality. (PDF pp.112, 114, 121)

Graham Wallas and Arthur Bentley
Early forerunners of behaviouralism who shift attention toward actual behaviour and informal processes. (PDF p.118)

Charles Merriam
Calls for scientific rigour, interdisciplinarity and behavioural inquiry. (PDF pp.118-119)

Harold Lasswell
Develops politics as the analysis of power and policy. (PDF p.119)

David Easton
Gives both the behavioural framework and the later post-behavioural call for relevance and action. (PDF pp.120-122)

MECHANISM

A named proposition earns marks only when it is tied to the analytical use the question demands.

TRAP / LIMIT

Value-free means politically consequence-free -> Behavioural inquiry can shape what gets studied and ignored, which is why post-behaviouralism raised the issue of relevance. (PDF pp.121-122)

ANSWER LINE

"Everybody ought to vote if democracy is to work" is empirical in content because its claim can be checked against political functioning. (PDF pp.110-111)

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ILLUSTRATIONS ATTACHED TO THE CLAIMS THEY SUPPORT

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"Everybody ought to vote if democracy is to work" is empirical in content because its claim can be checked against political functioning. (PDF pp.110-111)

"Justice is treating equals equally
"Justice is treating equals equally..." is normative in content even though it appears in the form of an "is" statement. (PDF p.110)

Legal analysis of Indian politics would ask what
Legal analysis of Indian politics would ask what constitutional provisions authorize institutions and actions. (PDF pp.115-116)

Institutional analysis would map legislature, executive,
Institutional analysis would map legislature, executive, judiciary, parties and their formal relations. (PDF pp.116-117)

Behavioural analysis of the same political scene would ask
Behavioural analysis of the same political scene would ask how voters, leaders, parties and interest groups actually behave

MECHANISM

Examples are evidence only when the answer states what they prove and where they stop proving it.

TRAP / LIMIT

Post-behaviouralism means abandoning science for activism -> Easton presents it as retaining behavioural gains while reconnecting them to problem-solving. (PDF pp.121-122)

ANSWER LINE

Method and approach are synonyms. -> Approach is wider because it includes selection-criteria for problems and data. (PDF pp.108-109)

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COMPARISON MATRIX

Approach cluster	Core claim	Main focus	Limitation flagged by Gauba
Traditional	Politics is illuminated through philosophy, history, law and institutions. (PDF pp.109-117)	Concepts, thought, legal framework, institutions. (PDF pp.113-117)	Often descriptive or normative without enough behavioural/process analysis. (PDF pp.117-118)
Behavioural	Political science should study actual political behaviour scientifically through regularities, verification, techniques and quantification. (PDF pp.118-121)	Individuals, attitudes, participation, communication, decision-processes. (PDF pp.119-121)	Risk of excessive micro-focus, method-fetish and value-neutral distance from urgent public issues. (PDF pp.121-122)
Post-behavioural	Science should remain rigorous but also relevant, action-oriented and attentive to value-construction. (PDF pp.121-122)	Social problems, public responsibility, applied knowledge. (PDF pp.121-122)	It must not become a licence for untested moralism; relevance still needs disciplined inquiry

MECHANISM

Running the comparison on shared axes converts a description into an adjudication.

ANSWER LINE

These eight "tenets"/"intellectual foundation stones" are commonly attributed, via Gauba's exposition, to David Easton's account of behaviouralism (echoing Easton's own 1969 listing). Treat

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EXAMINER TRAP FIREWALL

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TRAP Value-free means politically consequence-free

REPAIR Behavioural inquiry can shape what gets studied and ignored, which is why post-behaviouralism raised the issue of relevance. (PDF pp.121-122)

TRAP Post-behaviouralism means abandoning science for activism

REPAIR Easton presents it as retaining behavioural gains while reconnecting them to problem-solving. (PDF pp.121-122)

MECHANISM Each pair is a tested misreading followed by the exact repair the source supports.

ANSWER LINE Post-behaviouralism is a corrective within science, not a licence for unexamined activism; relevance still requires disciplined evidence, or it collapses back into the untested moralism

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OWNERSHIP BOUNDARIES AND CROSS-LINKS

THIS TOPIC OWNS

- Sections 13-19 of this file already reconstruct the eight behavioural tenets and all five analytical models (Easton, Almond, Deutsch, decision-making, Marxian) with claim->evidence->significance->limit; use Political-Theory/advanced/08_Approaches-Behaviouralism-and-Post-Behaviouralism.md only for further comparative depth and extra answer-engine prompts, not as a requirement for full marks
- Read Political-Theory/basic/07_Nature-of-Politics-and-Communitarianism.md first if the nature of politics itself is unclear
- Use Political-Theory/00_Master-Framework.md for the module-wide theory/science decode engine
- Use Political-Theory/README.md for the topic map and tag policy
- Boundary: this file explains ways of studying politics; it does not duplicate detailed constitutional or public-administration content

DELEGATED OR EXCLUDED

- Direct constitutional, scheme and case facts

MECHANISM Syllabus boundary discipline prevents a conceptual answer from being marked down as off-topic.

ANSWER LINE Claim: the political system is best understood as an open system embedded in a wider social environment, processing inputs (demands and supports from citizens/groups) through a conversion

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REVISION CAPSULE AND ANSWER SPINE

- Method = procedure; approach = procedure plus problem/data selection. (PDF pp.108-109)

- Empirical vs normative depends on content, not grammar alone. (PDF pp.110-112)

- Traditional approaches: philosophical, historical, legal, institutional. (PDF pp.112-117)

- Behaviouralism: scientific study of actual behaviour, eight key tenets, micro-level reliability. (PDF pp.118-121)

- Post-behaviouralism: relevance, action and responsible value concern without discarding scientific gains. (PDF pp.121-122)

- Best answer line: political inquiry needs both disciplined evidence and defensible value judgment

MECHANISM The capsule is the last-minute recall rail; it should be reproducible in under two minutes.

ANSWER LINE Model - Core unit of analysis - Main strength - Main limitation

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GS MAINS QUESTION ROUTES CARRIED BY THIS TOPIC

10-mark route

Distinguish method from approach in political inquiry and explain why the distinction matters. Answer in 150 words

10-mark route

Why must empirical and normative statements be classified by content rather than grammatical form? Answer in 150 words

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MECHANISM	Syllabus boundary discipline prevents a conceptual answer from being marked down as off-topic.
ANSWER LINE	Claim: the political system is best understood as an open system embedded in a wider social environment, processing inputs (demands and supports from citizens/groups) through a conversion

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GS MAINS QUESTION ROUTES CARRIED BY THIS TOPIC

10-mark route	10-mark route
Distinguish method from approach in political inquiry and explain why the distinction matters. Answer in 150 words	Why must empirical and normative statements be classified by content rather than grammatical form? Answer in 150 words
10-mark route	15-mark route
Examine behaviouralism's eight tenets and its contribution to political science. Answer in 150 words	Evaluate post-behaviouralism as a correction of, rather than a rejection of, behaviouralism. Answer in 250 words
15-mark route	15-mark route
Compare the systems, structural-functional, communications, decision-making and Marxian models of political analysis. Answer in 250 words	Can political science be value-free? Discuss with reference to behaviouralism, Strauss and post-behaviouralism. Answer in 250 words
MECHANISM	Directive fidelity, not content volume, decides the band a Mains answer lands in.
ANSWER LINE	1. Objection: behavioural political science's value-neutrality claim makes it complicit in ignoring urgent injustice, since choosing what to study/ignore is itself a value-laden act

QUALIFIED VERDICT
These eight "tenets"/"intellectual foundation stones" are commonly attributed, via Gauba's exposition, to David Easton's account of behaviouralism (echoing Easton's own 1969 listing). Treat. Claim: the political system is best understood as an open system embedded in a wider social environment, processing inputs (demands and supports from citizens/groups) through a conversion. The mark therefore comes from the qualification: state the strongest case, then the limit at which it stops being defensible.